

Urban Collaboration Checklist

A practical framework for cities: should we collaborate, and how?

The one-page checklist

For practical use, the entire framework can be reduced to this checklist.

Before collaborating

- ☐ Is the problem clearly defined?
- ☐ Is there evidence supporting the diagnosis?
- ☐ Is collaboration actually necessary?
- ☐ Is there a shared purpose?
- ☐ Are the right partners involved?

Before committing

- ☐ Do partners trust one another sufficiently?
- ☐ Do they understand each other's strengths?
- ☐ Is there a genuine reason to act now?
- ☐ Does each partner have sufficient capacity?
- ☐ Are leadership teams aligned?

Before starting

- ☐ Are roles clear?
- ☐ Are decision-making arrangements clear?
- ☐ Are resources identified?
- ☐ Is the government/community interface understood?
- ☐ Are data responsibilities clear?
- ☐ Are risks identified?

During implementation

- ☐ Are partners communicating regularly?
- ☐ Are assumptions being tested?
- ☐ Is feedback being collected?
- ☐ Are disagreements being surfaced?
- ☐ Are partners learning from implementation?
- ☐ Is the approach being adapted where necessary?

After the initial phase

- ☐ What changed?
- ☐ What did we learn?
- ☐ What worked?
- ☐ What did not work?
- ☐ What should be changed?
- ☐ Should the collaboration continue?
- ☐ Should it expand?
- ☐ Should it stop?
- ☐ What institutional capacity remains after the collaboration?

The 10-minute Urban Collaboration Test

Before signing an MoU or launching a joint project, partners should be able to answer these questions quickly.

The problem

1. What problem are we solving?

The people

2. Who is affected?

The purpose

3. What change are we trying to create?

The reason

4. Why can't each organisation reasonably do this alone?

The partners

5. Why are these particular organisations involved?

The contribution

6. What does each partner uniquely contribute?

The trigger

7. Why collaborate now?

The trust

8. What assumptions or concerns could undermine the partnership?

The capacity

9. Who has the time and resources to do the work?

The outcome

10. What will be different if the collaboration succeeds?

If these questions produce vague answers, the partnership may need more preparation before implementation.

An Urban Collaboration Scorecard

A checklist should not become another artificial scoring system.

Instead of giving a partnership a numerical "collaboration score," organisations can classify each area as:

Ready

Needs discussion

Not yet ready

For example:

Area	Status	Question
Shared problem	Ready	Do we understand the problem similarly?
Shared purpose	Needs discussion	Are expected outcomes aligned?
Complementary capabilities	Ready	Does each partner add something distinctive?
Trust	Needs discussion	Can we disagree constructively?
Leadership support	Ready	Are decision-makers committed?
Staff capacity	Not yet ready	Do people have time to participate?
Resources	Needs discussion	Who funds what?
Decision-making	Not yet ready	Who decides when partners disagree?
Learning	Ready	Have we created reflection points?
Outcome measurement	Needs discussion	How will we know whether the work matters?

The value is not the label.

The value is the conversation that produces it.

When collaboration may not be the answer

An honest framework should also identify situations where collaboration may not be appropriate.

Collaboration may add unnecessary complexity when:

- one organisation already has the required capability;
- the problem is clearly defined and operationally simple;
- partners have fundamentally incompatible objectives;
- no organisation has the capacity to participate;
- the partnership exists mainly for reputational reasons;
- the transaction costs exceed the likely value;
- responsibilities cannot be clearly assigned.

More collaboration is not automatically better.

The objective is useful collaboration, not collaboration for its own sake.

Read the full framework: urban.org.in/urban-collaboration-checklist · U-CAN, Urban Collective Action Network · connect@urban.org.in